

[< Corn](#)**AGRICULTURE**

Flea Beetles

Desert corn flea beetle: *Chaetocnema ectypa*

Palestriped flea beetle: *Systema blanda*

Potato flea beetle: *Epitrix cucumeris*

Threespotted flea beetle: *Disonycha triangularis*

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Description of the Pest

The potato flea beetle is a small (0.065 inch), shiny, black beetle. The threespotted flea beetle is two to three times larger and has an orange colored thorax on which are three prominent dark spots. The [palestriped flea beetle](#) is about twice as large as the potato flea

beetle. It is dark brown and has a longitudinal creamy white stripe on each wing cover. The desert corn flea beetle is 0.125 inch long and brownish with two pale yellowish stripes along the wings. All of the flea beetles have enlarged hind legs and jump vigorously when disturbed, thus the name flea beetle.

Damage

Damage is caused by adults. Feeding by the potato, palestriped, and threespotted flea beetles consists of numerous small rounded or irregular holes eaten in leaves so that leaves appear to have been peppered with small shot. Feeding by the desert corn flea beetle causes yellowish white feeding scars about 0.125 to 0.5 inches long along the leaf veins. In young plants particularly, the feeding damage can be very serious and can result in death. In addition to adult damage, larvae of the palestriped flea beetle feeds on roots of young plants as well as on germinating seeds.

Management

No economic thresholds are available but treatments, especially on young plants, should be considered if damage reaches a moderate level. Keep fields weed-free, particularly of [field bindweed](#) and [mustard](#), which are preferred hosts of flea beetles. Heavily damaged fields should be replanted.

Pesticides and Natural Enemy Releases

Not all registered pesticides are listed. **The following are ranked by their IPM value, with the most effective and least harmful to natural enemies, honey bees, and the [environment](#) listed at the top of the table.** When choosing a pesticide, consider information related to water and [air quality](#), resistance management, and the pesticide's properties and

application timing. Use [PestManage](#) to compare summarized management options for different pests in the same crop. Always carefully read the label of the product being used and take all necessary [precautions when handling pesticides](#).



[Expand table](#)

Rank	Active ingredient	Example trade
Application Timing Varies (See <i>UC IPM Pest Management</i>		
A	carbaryl—XLR formulation [*]	Sevin XLR Plus

- No information.
- I

Do not apply or allow to drift to plants that are flowering including weeds. Do not allow pesticide to contaminate water accessible to bees including puddles.
- II

Do not apply or allow to drift to plants that are flowering including weeds, except when the application is made between sunset and midnight if allowed by the pesticide label and regulations. Do not allow pesticide to contaminate water accessible to bees including puddles.
- III

No bee precaution, except when required by the pesticide label or regulations.

- ‡ ^{a b}Restricted entry interval (REI) is the number of hours (unless otherwise noted) from treatment until the treated area can be safely entered without personal protective equipment. Preharvest interval (PHI) is the number of days from treatment to harvest. In some cases, the REI exceeds the PHI. The longer of the two intervals is the minimum time that must elapse before harvest.

- * [a](#) Permit required from county agricultural commissioner for purchase or use.
- ¹ [↩](#) Group numbers for insecticides and miticides are assigned by the [Insecticide Resistance Action Committee](#) (IRAC). Insecticides with unknown modes of action are assigned mode-of-action group numbers (MoAs) that begin with UN. Rotate pesticides with a different mode-of-action group number, and do not use products with the same mode-of-action group number more than twice per season to help prevent the development of resistance. For example, the organophosphates have a group number of 1B; insecticides with a 1B group number should be alternated with insecticides that have a group number other than 1B.
- ² [↩](#) Range of insect and mite groups affected by a pesticide. **Broad** means the pesticide affects most groups of insects and mites; **narrow** means the pesticide affects only a few specific groups.
- ³ [↩](#) Risk of harm to honey bees. For more information, see [Bee Precaution Pesticide Ratings](#).
- ⁴ [↩](#) Risk of harm to predatory mites. Toxicities are generally to western predatory mite, *Galendromus occidentalis*. Where differences have been measured in toxicity of the pesticide-resistant strain versus the native strain, these are listed as pesticide-resistant strain or native strain.
- ⁵ [a b](#) Risk of harm to parasitoids and general predators. Toxicities are averages of reported effects and should be used only as a general guide. Actual toxicity of a specific insecticide depends on factors including the application rate, environmental conditions, and the life stage and species of a parasitoid or predator.
- ⁶ [↩](#) Length of time residue affects natural enemies. **Short** means hours to days; **moderate** means days to 2 weeks; and **long** means many weeks or months.

- ⁷ [↩](#) Risk of harm to fish from leaching, based on USDA Natural Resources Conservation Service Windows Pesticide Screening Tool (WIN-PST).
- ⁸ [↩](#) Risk of harm to fish from adsorbed runoff, based on USDA Natural Resources Conservation Service Windows Pesticide Screening Tool (WIN-PST).
- ⁹ [↩](#) Risk of harm to fish from solution runoff, based on USDA Natural Resources Conservation Service Windows Pesticide Screening Tool (WIN-PST).
- ¹⁰ [↩](#) Risk of harm to humans from leaching, based on USDA Natural Resources Conservation Service Windows Pesticide Screening Tool (WIN-PST).
- ¹¹ [↩](#) Risk of harm to humans from solution runoff, based on USDA Natural Resources Conservation Service Windows Pesticide Screening Tool (WIN-PST).
- ¹² [↩](#) Date information was last updated in the *UC IPM Pest Management Guidelines*.



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